

What Caused the Cold War?

Build an evidence-based answer to a contested question: what caused the Cold War, and who bears more responsibility for its onset?

? Historical challenge

By 1946 the wartime alliance between the United States and the Soviet Union had collapsed into mutual suspicion. Historians agree on the sequence of events but disagree sharply about the cause — and about who was more responsible. Weigh the evidence, note what conflicts and what is missing, and build a defensible working conclusion.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Kennan and Containment, 1947 – Office of the Historian, U.S. Dept. of State

SECONDARY SOURCE

Government history of Kennan's 'long telegram' and the birth of containment.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did Kennan explain Soviet behavior?
- How reliable is a single diplomat's analysis of a rival power?

SOURCES 2

Truman Doctrine – Harry S. Truman Library

PRIMARY SOURCE

Truman's March 1947 message requesting aid for Greece and Turkey.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does Truman frame the choice facing the world?
- What might this speech leave out or exaggerate?

SOURCES 3

Telegram from Nikolai Novikov to the Soviet Leadership (Sept. 1946) – Wilson Center Digital Archive

PRIMARY SOURCE

The Soviet ambassador's warning that the U.S. sought global domination.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does the Soviet view mirror the American one?
- Why is it important to read both sides' cables?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

Historical question

What caused the Cold War — and who bears more responsibility for its onset (roughly 1945–1950): the United States or the Soviet Union?

What we think we know

1 Evidence 1

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

2 Evidence 2

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

3 Evidence 3

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

Conflicting evidence

Missing evidence

Working conclusion

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your evidence cards with a partner. Did you rate the same sources as reliable?
- Did you and your partner lean toward the same 'school' of interpretation? What evidence moved you?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Write a working conclusion answering the historical question. Cite at least two evidence cards, acknowledge conflicting interpretations, and note one limitation of your evidence.